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INTERNATIONAL DIPLOMATIC COUNCIL OF TAMIL EELAM

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STATEMENT
23rd of July 2025

Black July: Honoring the victims, Demanding Accountability

Today, on 23rd of July, IDCTE solemnly marks the 41st anniversary of Black July. A horrific chapter in Eelam Tamils' history that saw the state-sponsored genocidal pogrom. We honor the memory of the thousands of Tamil lives lost during Black July.

It was one of the most well documented state-led genocidal pogrom that unleashed the violent fury of racism. Several thousands of Tamils were killed in a matter of days, with state collusion with precise information about Tamil residents and their businesses, led by state actors including monks and police.

Tamil homes, businesses and properties were stormed, looted and attacked. Many were raped, sexually assaulted, stripped naked and beaten to death. Hundreds of Tamils were burned alive. As a result of the hatred that erupted into volcanic violence on an unprecedented scale, over 3,000 Tamils were killed, around 18,000 homes were attacked, over 100 000 Tamils displaced, over 5,000 businesses were destroyed and many forced to flee the island permanently.

For over two days, the Sri Lankan government remained silent. deliberately allowing the violence to spread, targeting the economic base of the Tamil businesses. Even the Tamil political prisoners at the Welikande prison were brutally killed with the collusion of the prison officers.

This genocide act was actively fueled and encouraged by provocative statements from Sri Lanka state's leadership. On 11th of July in 1983, Sri Lanka's president J.R. Jayewardene declared: *"If I starve the Tamils out, the Sinhala people will be happy"*. This comment not only revealed the state's deep rooted genocidal intent, but also served as a green light, giving public and political cover for the anti-Tamil pogrom that followed.

The narrative that Black July was a response to the killing of 13 Sinhalese soldiers is a misconception. There had been periodic anti-Tamil programs since 1958 and had already been escalating with Tamils facing torture, detention and extrajudicial killings well before Black July. In 1983 alone, violence by state actors had escalated in the months leading up to Black July, with Tamils being killed at will. Not a single perpetrator from the state-sponsored violence has been held accountable.

IDCTE reaffirms its unwavering commitment to holding the perpetrators of Tamil Genocide accountable, through our consistent advocacy with policy makers and international institutions, in an effort to raise awareness on the right narratives.